for Hayes and Harlington, said Britain should apologize because it had willingly provided military support to desecrate Sikhism's holiest site. William Hague accused McDonnell of wild distortion, pointing out that the SAS officer who was sent to India in 1984 had provided advice to the Indian intelligence service (R&AW) and its special group (SFF) with the aim of minimizing casualties. This was ignored when the Indian army took charge of Operation Blue Star and stormed into the Golden Temple in June that year.

Hague also said there was no evidence that the SAS officer was sent to India to help British defence sales to India. But Tom Watson, a former Labour minister, said the House of Commons had been told that a protest march (by UK Sikhs) to commemorate victims of Operation Blue Star was not permitted on public-order grounds. He also quoted from newly released cabinet minutes from that time, which said: 'In view of the importance of the British political and commercial interests at stake it would be necessary to explore every possibility of preventing the march taking place. Export contracts worth five billion pounds could be at stake.' [5]

To this, Hague told Watson that the cabinet secretary was 'making a different point about a different event' because there was no evidence in the files that Britain provided military advice to boost defence sales.

Douglas Alexander, Labour's shadow secretary of state for foreign and commonwealth affairs, said, 'Labour welcomes what light the Cabinet Secretary's report sheds on the allegations of British involvement in Operation Blue Star, but despite the publication of this report, serious questions will continue to be asked.' He went on to say, 'It remains unclear, for example, why the government has today chosen to publish Mrs Gandhi's letter to Mrs Thatcher, but not Mrs Thatcher's letter to Mrs Gandhi. The pain and suffering still felt by many about the tragic events of 1984 places a particular duty on the government to provide what answers it can to address very genuine concerns.'

Winding up the debate, Prime Minister David Cameron said, 'I hope the manner in which we have investigated these dreadful events will provide some reassurance to the Sikh community, here in Britain and elsewhere.' He said, '... a single UK military officer